2.4 War and Witch Trials

The continued takeover of Native American lands by colonists caused conflicts in the 1670s. Conflicts also arose among colonists, and in one New England town, accusations of witchcraft and wickedness flew.

MAIN IDEA In the late 1600s, wars with Native Americans raged in the New England colonies and witch trials nearly tore the town of Salem apart.

KING PHILIP'S WAR

In 1671, because of increasing tensions with Native Americans, the Plymouth government forced the Wampanoag to surrender their guns. Four years later, a chain of events led to a bloody war.

A Native American named John Sassamon was a convert to Christianity and an interpreter for English colonists. Soon after he warned of an impending attack by a Wampanoag leader named **Metacom**, he was found dead. With little or no evidence, authorities tried and hanged three Wampanoag for his murder.

In response, Metacom and his troops attacked 52 towns throughout New England, destroying 12 of them completely. By the next summer, Metacom's troops were suffering from disease, hunger, and a shortage of weapons, so the campaign came to an end.

English settlers had given Metacom the nickname "King Philip"—no one remembers why—and these attacks became known as **King Philip's War**. Around 600 colonists and thousands of Native Americans died in the war, including Metacom.

ACCUSATIONS IN SALEM

In February 1692, authorities in the village of Salem, Massachusetts, accused three women of witchcraft. Presumably, the charges stemmed from the strange behavior of some village girls. But it didn't take long for people to believe that witches existed and were living in Salem.

Authorities began to arrest people accused by fellow villagers. Nearly 200 women and men were accused and brought to trial for witchcraft. "Evidence" consisted largely of accusations and little more. Twenty of the accused were put to death, most by hanging.

Historians think the issue underlying the trials may have been women's ownership of property. In Puritan society, women were rarely allowed to own property. When a man died, his son or sons usually inherited his property. If he had no male children, his wife or daughter could inherit.

Many Salem residents accused of witchcraft were women who had inherited property. Their status as property owners went against the societal norm and threatened to challenge traditional gender roles. The threat posed by women as property owners may have driven many witchcraft accusations.

Governor William Phips and Increase Mather, an influential minister, initially supported the trials but then realized things had gone too far. By May 1693, Phips had pardoned all of those still imprisoned. Additionally, courts dismissed charges and returned not-guilty verdicts in the remaining cases. The strange episode of the Salem witch trials was over.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did Metacom attack New England towns?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What effect did King Philip's War have on Native Americans in the region?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why were landowning women targets of witchcraft accusations?

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- The Wonders of the Invisible World.

OBSERVATIONS

As well *Historical* as *Theological*, upon the NATURE, the NUMBER, and the OPERATIONS of the

DEVILS.

Accompany'd with,

I. Some Accounts of the Grievous Moleſtations, by DÆMONS and WITCHCRAFTS, which have lately annoy'd the Countrey; and the Trials of ſome eminent *Malefactors* Executed upon occaſion thereof: with ſeveral Remarkable *Curioſities* therein occurring.

II. Some Counſils, Directing a due Improvement of the terrible things, lately done, by the Unuſual & Amazing Range of EVIL SPIRITS, in Our Neighbourhood: & the methods to prevent the *Wrongs* which thoſe *Evil Angels* may intend againſt all ſorts of people among us; eſpecially in Accuſations of the Innocent.

III. Some Conjectures upon the great EVENTS, likely to befall, the WORLD in General, and NEW-ENGLAND in Particular; as alſo upon the Advances of the TIME, when we ſhall ſee BETTER DAYES.

IV. A ſhort Narrative of a late Outrage committed by a knot of WITCHES in *Swedeland*, very much Reſembling, and ſo far Explaining, *That* under which our parts of *America* have laboured!

V. THE DEVIL DISCOVERED: In a Brief Diſcourſe upon thoſe TEMPTATIONS, which are the more Ordinary *Devices* of the Wicked One.

By Cotton Mather.

Boſton, Printed by *Benj. Harris* for *Sam. Phillips*. 1693.

CRITICAL VIEWING The fiery New England preacher named Cotton Mather wrote a book on the Salem witch trials. At left is a page from his book. In the 1890s, 200 years after the Salem witch trials, illustrator Joseph E. Baker reimagined the events reported to have taken place in Salem. What are the different ways witches are portrayed in Mather's writing and these drawings?





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